Healthcare Legal Partnership Needs Assessment

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Background

One in six low-income individuals in the U.S. has at least one unmet legal need that negatively affect health.[1] The following are examples:

- unjust loss of income or insurance
- unstable housing or utilities
- discrimination in education or employment due to disability
- immigration status
- personal and family stability

Healthcare Legal Partnerships improve the health of patients by addressing unmet health-harming legal needs through the integration of civil legal services in healthcare settings.

Focus of Study

A needs assessment of a federally qualified health center in St. Paul, Minnesota, will be conducted to explore the necessity of a healthcare legal partnership.

Initial results will be analyzed before undertaking a more extensive needs assessment in other federally qualified health centers in the Twin Cities area.

Impact of Healthcare Legal Partnerships

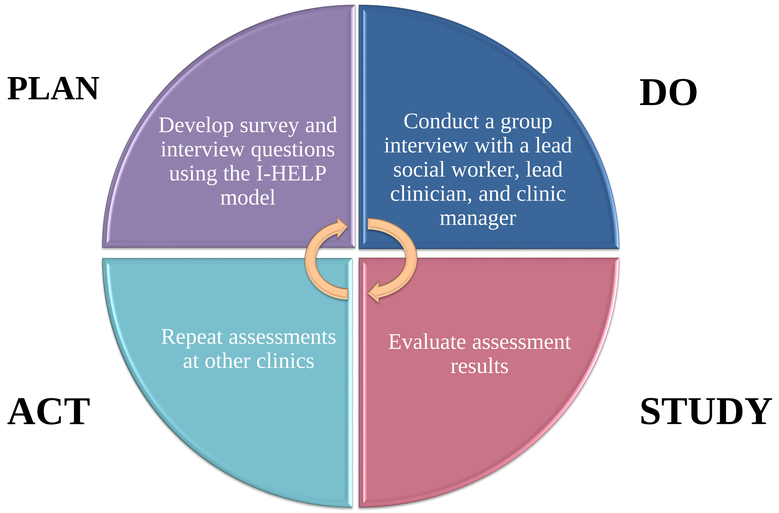
In 2010, attorneys and health care providers collaborated to enforce existing laws that protect children, elderly, and chronically ill individuals from utility shutoffs. During the first year of the project, physicians advocated for 193 people to prevent utility shutoffs and a year later helped a total of 676 individuals.[2]

An evaluation study was conducted with three pediatric primary care centers that served predominantly high-risk populations in Cincinnati, Ohio. The study found that over a three year time period, nearly 6,000 household were served. Over 1,700 positive legal outcomes included:

- improvements in housing conditions
- resumption of public benefits
- implementation of appropriate educational services
- provision of valuable legal advice[3]

Quality Improvement Approach

Plan-Do-Study-Act (PDSA) is an effective tool to test quality improvement[4] and was applied to the study.



I-HELP

The I-HELP model is used by healthcare legal partnerships to assess the health-harming legal needs of patients.

I-HELP Categories	Example	Related Assessment Question
Income Support & Insurance	food stamps, disability benefits, cash assistance, health insurance	How often do your patients discuss being turned down for public benefits?
Housing & Utilities	eviction, housing conditions, housing vouchers, utility shut off	How have you seen housing issues affect the health of your patients?
Employment & Education	accommodation for disease and disability in education and employment setting	How often do you see patients who need but don't receive disability benefits to which they are entitled?
Legal Status	criminal background issues, consumer law status, military discharge status, immigration status	How have you seen immigration status affect health?
Personal & Family Stability	domestic violence, guardian-ship, child support, advanced directives, estate planning	How often do your patients discuss feeling threatened or unsafe in their home?

Timeline

Activities	June	July	Aug	Sept	Oct
IRB review	x				
Community assessment	x	x			
Development of survey and interview questions		x			
Clinic recruitment		x	x	x	
Conduct assessment				x	
Analysis results					x

Next Steps

Finalize clinic participation schedule.

Conduct needs assessment.

Analyze the results of the initial clinic assessment.

Revise the assessment process to best determine the legal needs of federally qualified health centers.

Conduct the assessment of federally qualified health centers in the Twin Cities area.

Footnotes

[1] Weber, E. P., & Polkey, B. (2016). Nurses' roles in healthcare legal partnerships. *Interdisciplinary Journal of Partnership Studies*, *3*(1), 3.

[2] Medical Legal Partnerships. (2010). Changing the law to keep the heat and lights on. Retrieved from http://medical-legalpartnership.org/utility-story

[3] Klein, M. D., Beck, A. F., Henize, A. W., Parrish, D. S., Fink, E. E., & Kahn, R. S. (2013). Doctors and lawyers collaborating to HeLP children—: Outcomes from a successful partnership between professions. *Journal of Health Care for the Poor and Underserved*, *24*(3), 1063-1073.

[4] Institute for Healthcare Improvement. (2016). Plan-Do-Study-Act (PDSA) worksheet. Retrieved from: http://www.ihi.org/resources/pages/tools/plandostudyactworksheet.aspx

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